

Executive Summary

Purpose and research question. Generative AI has become central to marketing, which together with sales is projected to capture roughly a third of AI's economic value (Mayer et al., 2025). Yet most marketing AI still works as a question-and-answer tool. A newer category, *agentic AI*, can pursue goals autonomously across complex, multi-step tasks and so promises to perform the work itself. How managers turn that promise into value is largely unexplored, and scholars have issued explicit calls for firm-level evidence (Kim, 2025; Mogaji & Jain, 2024; Jain et al., 2024). This study therefore asks: *How do marketing managers create value with agentic AI?* Three sub-questions examine how managers identify and translate opportunities, adopt agentic AI within their organizations, and manage the benefits, sacrifices, and risks it brings.

Method. The study applies constructivist grounded theory (Charmaz, 2014), an exploratory qualitative approach suited to an emerging phenomenon. Seventeen in-depth, semi-structured interviews with marketing managers and AI experts were analyzed iteratively through initial, focused, and theoretical coding, with theoretical sampling continued until saturation. Value theory (Almquist et al., 2016; Woodside et al., 2008) served as a sensitizing concept.

Main findings. Value is created not by adopting agentic AI but by the managerial work surrounding it. The study's central contribution is a process model that links five elements: *observing* external conditions (the progression of AI, market pressure, and supplier roadmaps); *navigating* the organizational conditions that enable or constrain action; *steering* the organization by reshaping, leveraging, and navigating those conditions; *applying* agentic AI through specific use cases and a deliberately engineered configuration, the *harness*; and the resulting *value outcomes*, understood as a managed portfolio of benefits, sacrifices, and risks. Identical use cases produced divergent outcomes across firms; the difference lay in the managerial work and the configuration, not the technology. A pattern of paradoxes runs throughout: the technology that creates a risk also supplies the means to govern it.

Practical implications. Managers should treat adoption as a change program rather than a procurement: build the enabling conditions and lead the change; consciously choose a follow (parity) or a differentiate posture; start from the workflow and engineer the configuration; govern AI with AI, calibrated to the cost of error; resource and source capability strategically; and look outward to consumers' own agents and to the junior-talent pipeline. Appendix B turns these into an operational checklist.

Theoretical implications. The findings extend digital-transformation theory (Enholm et al., 2022; Vidal et al., 2022; Gebauer et al., 2020); notably, governance shifts from an enabler to an inhibitor of adoption. The study also specifies the configuration through which an agentic system becomes a value-creating actor (Orlikowski, 2000; Vargo & Lusch, 2017).

Limitations. As a qualitative study of a fast-moving technology, the findings are transferable but context-bound, and observations tied to specific use cases may date quickly. The study relies exclusively on self-reported interview data.

Originality. This is one of the first grounded empirical accounts of value creation with agentic AI in marketing. It moves beyond the field's prevailing focus on content generation and offers a process model, together with an analytical vocabulary (reshaping, leveraging, and navigating; the harness; and value as a managed portfolio), for understanding the managerial work that turns agentic AI into value.